OpenParlData Challenge — Q&A from the 08.10 Session

Extracting parliamentary affairs from PDFs into one common structure. Contact: **info@openparldata.ch** · Admin panel: **https://admin.openparldata.ch/**

Getting started & access

Where do I get the data, and how do I access the admin panel? Data is available via the OpenParlData API and bulk exports, and there's an admin panel at **admin.openparldata.ch**. For those who want to work on the dataset directly, Christian can grant **editor access** — register for the admin panel and request editor rights by email (**info@openparldata.ch**).

The export server seems rate-limited (~0.5 MB/s), and the full export is ~10 GB of NDJSON — it takes very long. Christian suggested trying **sequential downloads rather than parallel curls** — hitting it with many parallel requests may be what's slowing you down. If problems persist after switching to serial, report it and he'll **investigate the Hetzner server export** further. (One participant was going to re-test with a serial download.)

Is there an IP allow-list / block on the export server? Not confirmed as the cause — try the serial approach first; if it still fails, flag it to Christian to look into.

Scope & approach

This is huge — where should I start? Start **small**. Affairs can be very complex and may be too extensive to fully structure, so focus on a **smaller subset** and on the **key structures** first — e.g. the submitted text (submission) and the government's answer — rather than trying to capture everything in the PDFs. The PDFs can remain available for consultation while the structured data captures only the essential information.

What's the actual goal — what am I building toward? Turning parliamentary documents into **structured, (linked) data** — a knowledge graph of parliamentary affairs, in the spirit of the Jolux / Fedlex ecosystems (RDF/XML). The broader aim is to make parliamentary information more granular, navigable and analysable, so people can monitor affairs and events over time. All the data is public.

Do I have to produce RDF/XML specifically? RDF/XML (linked-data) was the direction discussed by participants (Jonathan's approach), aligned with Jolux/Fedlex. The challenge itself is about designing a **common structured representation** and a converter that

produces it — the exact serialization is part of what you're exploring; discuss your intended format with Christian.

Data model & edge cases

Some bodies have documents but no affairs — and some documents have no affair number. Should the converter create affairs in those cases, or skip them? This is a genuinely open design question (raised by Tim: 8 of 97 bodies hold documents but not a single affair; 17 of 72 sampled documents print no affair number). Two options were on the table:

- **the document itself becomes the identity** (so the converter creates affairs where none exist) — but then there's no affair ID / external_id to anchor a Wikidata "OpenParlData ID" property to; or
- **the converter stays limited to documents already attached to an affair**, leaving those bodies out. Christian's steer: focus on **bodies that have affairs with documents**, and he noted the difficulty of extracting affair numbers when they aren't present in the meeting documents. *Confirm your chosen handling with Christian for your subset.*

The harmonised affair *state* is empty for almost all affairs (325,321 of 325,599). Is that because state is bound to each parliament's rules of procedure, or just not done yet? And do you want a state schema or a per-parliament mapping table? Christian explained the harmonisation so far: **464 source labels mapped onto 18 terms with Wikidata IDs**, and acknowledged the current system needs improvement. The implication discussed: because procedural states differ per parliament, an **event model** (date, actor, label verbatim as printed) with harmonisation kept as a **maintained per-parliament table** (like the 464→18 mapping) may fit better than a single state model. *Which of the two to deliver — the schema or the table — is worth confirming directly with Christian for your work.*

The harmonised document types have no type for the submitted text of an affair or for the government's response, and many documents have no category. Will these be added? Noted as a real gap — document types/categories need improvement, and there's ongoing work on **standardised affair/document types via the eCH standard**. If the data told the converter each document's role, it wouldn't have to guess it. *Treat document-role as something you may need to infer for now; raise specifics with Christian.*

What entities does the current data model already contain? Affairs, meetings/events, documents, and contributors — with scrapers already extracting data daily and organising it by affairs and events (documents from both parliament and government sources). The goal is to make this more granular and navigable.

Compute & models

What compute is available? Can I use a lot of CPU/GPU? CPU resources are limited due to server constraints, and GPU availability is constrained. For LLM access, check the **admin panel** — **Apertus via Infomaniak** was mentioned as a potential route. Plan for a lightweight / sampled approach rather than assuming large-scale compute.

One run reportedly took ~20 hours — why, and how do I avoid that? Flagged in chat; long runtimes point to the scale/complexity of processing the full corpus. The practical answer ties back to "start small": work on a **representative subset** rather than the whole corpus while developing, to keep iteration fast.

Next steps mentioned in the session

- **Register** for the admin panel (https://admin.openparldata.ch/) and **request editor rights** from Christian by email (info@openparldata.ch).
- If you build a **gold / "golden" dataset**, you can **submit it to Christian for review** (by email or file upload); review timing depends on his availability.
- Report any **export-server issues** (rate limits, failures) so he can investigate the Hetzner export.

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*Still have questions? Post them in the challenge Discord channel or email **info@openparldata.ch** ahead of the mid-term Q&A.*